

OPINION

The fleeting unity following 9/11 is impossible in today's political climate. Here's why.

It was my naive belief that the January 6th assault on our nation's Capitol could serve as a similar rallying point unifying our deeply fractured country.



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World War II. The moon landing. The fall of the Berlin Wall. JFK's assassination. These shared experiences united contemporary Americans. No event in recent history, however, comes close to the unifying power of Sept. 11, 2001.

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That terrorist attack came on the heels of one of the most bitterly contested presidential elections in history. Was America divided after this election? Absolutely. Were the losing voters angry? Of course.

Yet less than a year later, a tidal wave of patriotism arising out of the 9/11 attacks swept these divisions aside. On the very night of this tragedy, both Republican and Democratic representatives stood together somberly on the Capitol steps, joining voices to sing "God Bless America."

It was my naive belief that the Jan. 6 assault on our nation's Capitol could serve as a similar rallying point unifying our deeply fractured country. The country would certainly unite against violent insurrectionists who stormed the Capitol to overturn a presidential election, wouldn't it? Our country surely could not countenance the injuring of more than 130 police officers (including one who subsequently died) and the perfidious calls to lynch the Republican vice president and the Democratic speaker of the House.

On the very night of this tragedy, outgoing President Trump dashed such hopes when he expressed his love for these treasonists. Since then, Trump and his political Janissaries have continued to offer aid and comfort to these turncoats, going so far as to cry that they were being persecuted. The political rubble left behind has proved far more toxic than that of the Twin Towers, as our elected officials were not able to muster enough unity to even launch a bipartisan investigation into the deadly insurrection.

The fleeting unity following 9/11 is impossible in today's political climate. The notion of shared facts, scientific truths and reasonable differing opinions now seems quaint. Instead, uncivil and false tweets proliferate. Seditious Facebook posts are spawned by specially selected algorithms designed to metastasize and spread unconstrained by traditional fact-checking. Partisan cable news shows intentionally sow division for profit, immediate attention, or the simple hatred of those they can paint as somehow different or foreign.

Ideally, Americans would yearn for unity and a shared sense of democratic norms. Yet our modern media ecosystem has seemingly gotten millions addicted to misinformation, lies, and distortions — a hallucinogenic cocktail that each day sucks more and more Americans into a dangerous, alternative-reality black hole.

In a country that can't even agree about whether the events surrounding Jan. 6 should be investigated, is it any wonder that we can't agree on the dangers posed by the coronavirus? Even if there were a vaccine for the division, distrust and hatred that now infects our body politic and national character, millions would refuse it.

Yet if we don't figure out how to neutralize the lies and hatred spawned by modern media, our democracy is unlikely to survive the current political epidemic. If so, the carnage this time (unlike the attack on the World Trade Center) would be entirely self-inflicted.

The center cannot hold; our democracy falls apart.

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